Talk Before You Marry · Leader's Guide

For pastors, mentoring couples and premarital group leaders walking with engaged couples through the 15 lessons

Pastor Richmond Kobe · Faithful Path · October 2026 · Final

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1. About this guide

Talk Before You Marry is a Christian premarital course for engaged couples, and for couples seriously considering engagement. It is based on the book of the same name by Pastor Richmond Kobe and follows it chapter by chapter. Its aim is simple: to help two people tell each other the truth before they make a covenant before God, and to keep telling it afterwards.

The course has 15 illustrated, narrated lessons of about 15 to 19 minutes each, in four parts:

- **Part 1 · Make Honesty Safe** (Lessons 1–2)
- **Part 2 · Learn the Skills** (Lessons 3–5)
- **Part 3 · Walk Through the Nine Rooms** (Lessons 6–14: money, sex, family and boundaries, children, faith and church, roles, past relationships, what you are marrying into, and conflict itself)
- **Part 4 · Keep Talking** (Lesson 15)

Each lesson opens with a passage of Scripture, explains it in its setting, often with one Hebrew or Greek word, and then teaches, with a prayer at the end. Below each lesson the couple finds the same four steps:

1. **Watch and listen**, together where they can.
2. **Prepare on your own**, each person alone, in private. Nothing typed on the page is saved.
3. **Talk together**, a guided conversation.
4. **Choose your next step**, and mark the lesson complete.

Further down are **Scripture to sit with**, **Talk about it** questions for groups and mentors, and **Go deeper**, which points to the matching chapter of the book.

This guide is for anyone who walks alongside engaged couples: a pastor, a mentoring couple, or the leader of a premarital group. For each lesson it gives the lesson's purpose, the passage and its background, a note on

the original word, the cautions the book itself gives, a **Don't miss this** box, the discussion questions, and a short note for mentors and pastors.

2. Ways to use the course

Setting	How it works
A couple with a pastor or mentoring couple	The couple watches each lesson and does both exercises at home. You meet every week or two to talk about the teaching and how the conversation went.
A premarital group	Couples watch at home or together, then discuss the **Talk about it** questions as a group. Each couple does the exercises privately at home.
A church premarital programme	Run the course over a term: Parts 1 and 2 (5 lessons), then Part 3 one room per session (9 lessons), then Lesson 15.
A couple on their own	The course is complete without a leader. A pastor's session can be booked through Faithful Path at any point.

Pace. One lesson a week is ideal, so that each conversation has time to settle. Parts 1 and 2 can be taken two lessons at a time if needed. **In Part 3, give each room a session of its own.** Lessons 7 (Sex), 11 (Roles), 12 (Past Relationships) and 14 (Conflict Itself) especially need unhurried time.

Order. Take the lessons in order. The skills of Part 2 are used in every room of Part 3, and Lesson 4 asks each couple to choose a first practice subject from the list they made in Lesson 1.

Completion. When a person finishes, the course records only that they completed it. It never says that a couple is "ready", "prepared" or "certified" for marriage. That judgement belongs to the couple, before God, with the counsel of their church.

3. Leading well, and when to pause or refer

- **Talk about the teaching, not about anyone's relationship.** Every **Talk about it** question is general. In a group, no one is asked to share their own answers, their partner's answers or their past.
- **Private preparation stays private.** Each person's private preparation belongs to them. Do not ask to see private lists, inventories, written reflections or disclosures. A couple may voluntarily share an agreement they have made together, such as their Rules of Engagement, but sharing is never a condition of taking part or of your approval.
- **If someone begins to share private details in a group,** thank them without inviting further details, remind everyone that personal matters can be discussed separately with an appropriate person, and do not ask the other partner to respond publicly.
- **Mentors do not report.** A mentoring couple does not pass a couple's private conversations to church leaders as routine progress information.
- **Keep Scripture in its setting.** Most passages in the course were not written about engagement. Each lesson says what the passage meant first, and then marks the application as an application. Model the same care when you lead.
- **Let differences stand.** On some questions, such as roles (Lesson 11) and family planning (Lesson 9), sincere Christians differ. The course presents the main views fairly and asks the couple to know their own church's teaching. Do not use a session to settle a debate.

When to pause or refer. Mentoring is pastoral friendship; it is not professional counselling, medical care, legal advice or safeguarding work. Pause the course and point the couple, or one person, to the right help when you meet:

- a serious unresolved difference of doctrine or church (their pastor or pastors);
- legal or financial obligations, such as custody, child support, divorce settlements, debt or contracts (a qualified professional where they live);
- medical questions (a qualified healthcare professional);
- pressure from family or community to marry;
- controlling behaviour, or a person who is afraid of how their partner will respond.

If someone is afraid of their partner. Speak with that person on their own, without the other partner's involvement. Do not suggest joint exercises, mediation or pressure to reconcile. Do not promise complete confidentiality where your church's safeguarding policy or the law requires you to act. Consult your church's designated safeguarding lead or an appropriate qualified service, and in immediate danger contact local emergency services. A mentoring couple is not expected to assess abuse or to counsel; their part is to listen, to take it seriously and to make sure the right people help. The lessons give the same instruction in one line before each **Talk together** step.

4. A session plan

For a group meeting of about 75 minutes:

Time	What happens
5 minutes	Welcome and prayer.
20 minutes	Watch the lesson together (or recap, if couples watched at home).
10 minutes	Read the main passage aloud from the ESV. Use the **Scripture and background** notes below.
25 minutes	**Talk about it** questions, as a whole group or in small groups.
10 minutes	Explain the two exercises; couples do them at home. Answer practical questions, but keep personal matters for a private conversation.
5 minutes	Close with the lesson's prayer, or your own.

For a mentoring couple, meet after the couple has done both exercises. Begin by asking how the conversation went, not what was said. Then use the **Don't miss this** box and one or two of the questions.

5. Handling Scripture and original words

- **The ESV is used throughout,** as in the book. Read the passages from the ESV in the session.
- **Original words are explained carefully.** Each word card shows the dictionary form of the word and, where it differs, the form in the verse. The Greek and Hebrew in the lessons were checked during the course's theological review, recorded in *Talk Before You Marry · Theological Reference Checks*, Version 33 (15 October 2026), which names the sources used (the German Bible Society's online NA28, BHS and Septuagint, with standard online dictionaries).
- **A meaning is not a doctrine.** Where a word's sense is debated, such as κεφαλή ("head") in Lesson 11, the course reports the debate rather than settling it by the dictionary.

- **Applications are marked.** When a passage written to a church (Ephesians 4, Colossians 3, Hebrews 3) is applied to a couple, the lesson says so. Do the same when you teach.

6. The lessons, one by one

PART 1 · MAKE HONESTY SAFE

Before a couple can discuss anything hard, it has to be safe to tell the truth.

Lesson 1 · Name What You're Afraid Of

What are we already avoiding — and why does it feel like peace?

At a glance	
Passage	Genesis 3:8–10
Also read	Genesis 2:25; 3:7, 21 · Proverbs 27:5–6a
The couple will see	Why silence can feel like peace, and why it is not the same thing (Genesis 3:8–10) · Six patterns that keep couples from the conversations they need · How the "map" you learned at home shapes the way you handle conflict · The question underneath many disagreements — and better questions to ask
Exercise	The Three Subjects (prepare alone, then talk together)
Length	About 18 minutes

Purpose. To show that silence is not the same as peace, and to help each person name, privately, the subjects they have been steering around, so that the course begins with honesty rather than performance.

Scripture and background. Genesis 2 ends with the man and the woman "naked and… not ashamed" (2:25). In Genesis 3 they disobey God, cover themselves (3:7) and hide among the trees (3:8). God comes looking: "Where are you?" (3:9). The man answers, "I was afraid… and I hid myself" (3:10). The passage is about sin, shame and fear before God; the lesson says so before applying it. It also shows the God who comes looking for those who hide, and who clothes them (3:21), while the chapter's real consequences remain. Proverbs 27:5–6 belongs to the wisdom on friendship and counsel: honest words from someone who cares are better than silence.

The book's cautions. The six patterns of avoidance are not called sins, and couples who avoid a hard subject are not committing the sin of Genesis 3. The lesson distinguishes an ordinary raised voice from a repeated pattern of threatening or controlling behaviour. Each person decides which of their subjects to share; a private list is never handed over.

Don't miss this
• Genesis 3 is about sin and shame before God; its use for couples is an application, and the lesson says so.
• God's first word to the hiding couple is a question, "Where are you?" He then confronts their disobedience and announces its consequences.
• The six patterns are not sins. They are ways good people avoid hard conversations.
• "The loving thing is not always the quiet thing."
• Each person chooses what to share from their list. Nobody reads another person's list.

Talk about it

1. Genesis 3 shows the first man and woman covering themselves and hiding. Why do you think hiding can feel safer than it is?
2. Which of the six patterns do you think is most common among engaged couples in your church or culture?
3. "The loving thing is not always the quiet thing." Where have you seen that to be true?

Remind the group: talk about the teaching, never about anyone's own relationship.

For mentors and pastors. Ask what the couple has noticed about how their families handled conflict. Do not ask what is on their lists.

Lesson 2 · Build a Relationship That Can Hold Disagreement

How do we make it safe to tell the truth before we ask for it?

At a glance	
Passage	Ephesians 4:25–32
Also read	Malachi 2:14 · Matthew 5:23–24
The couple will see	Why marriage is a covenant, not merely a contract, and why covenant never means captivity · What Ephesians 4:25–32 says about truthful speech that builds up · Eleven rules for hard conversations, agreed before you need them · How to choose the moment, and how to repair when it goes badly
Exercise	Your Rules of Engagement (prepare alone, then talk together)
Length	About 17 minutes

Purpose. To help a couple agree, before the hard conversations begin, how they will speak to each other when they disagree, so that telling the truth becomes safe.

Scripture and background. Ephesians 4:25–32 is written to a church: believers are "members one of another". Paul calls for truthful speech, anger that does not linger, honest work, words that build up and the forgiveness of those who have been forgiven in Christ. The lesson reads the passage in that setting and then applies it to two people preparing for marriage. Malachi 2:14 speaks of marriage as a covenant before God, witnessed by him. In Matthew 5:23–24 Jesus tells the worshipper to leave his gift at the altar and go first to be reconciled.

The original word. οἰκοδομή (oikodomē), "building up, edification" (Ephesians 4:29). In the verse the form is οἰκοδομὴν, "for building up". The word belongs to the language of construction and is related to οἶκος, a house. Paul uses it for believers strengthening one another. The application to a couple's words is the lesson's, and is marked as such.

The book's cautions. The eleven agreements are practical wisdom, not eleven commandments. Engagement is not yet marriage: covenant language is never used to pressure an engaged person to stay in a relationship. Rule four, "Scripture is not a weapon", matters for the rest of the course.

Don't miss this
• Ephesians 4 is written to a church; the lesson applies it to a couple and says so.

Don’t miss this

- oikodomē asks a builder’s question of our words: will this build?
- Malachi 2:14: marriage is a covenant made before God, not merely a private agreement.
- Jesus teaches us to take responsibility for reconciliation: where it is safe and appropriate, we take the initiative in addressing our own wrongdoing. This never requires anyone to return to danger or to repair a relationship alone.
- The agreements are practical guidance, not biblical commands.

Talk about it

1. What is the difference between a contract and a covenant, in your own words? Why does covenant make honesty safer?
2. Paul asks whether our words build up. What makes a hard truth “building” rather than “corrupting”?
3. Why do you think Jesus puts reconciliation before worship?

Remind the group: talk about the teaching, never about anyone’s own relationship.

For mentors and pastors. If the couple voluntarily shares any of their agreed Rules of Engagement, discuss how those rules protect both people, particularly the quieter partner. Do not ask to see their private preparation.

PART 2 · LEARN THE SKILLS

Three skills: telling yourself the truth, saying the hard thing, and hearing it.

Lesson 3 · Tell Yourself the Truth First

What do I actually expect — and where did it come from?

At a glance	
Passage	Proverbs 20:5
Also read	Psalm 139:1, 23–24 · Matthew 7:3–5 · Romans 14:5
The couple will see	How disappointment can reveal an expectation you never named · What Proverbs 20:5 teaches about the deep water of the heart, and who draws it out · How to sort an expectation: preference, conviction or deal-breaker · How to say what you actually want, specifically enough to be understood
Exercise	The Private Inventory (prepare alone, then talk together)
Length	About 19 minutes

Purpose. To help each person tell themselves the truth first: what they actually expect of marriage, where those expectations came from, and whether each is a preference, a conviction or a deal-breaker.

Scripture and background. Proverbs 20:5 is a wisdom saying about understanding another person: “The purpose in a man’s heart is like deep water, but a man of understanding will draw it out.” The lesson says this before applying the principle to self-knowledge. Psalm 139 is David’s prayer to the God who already knows him; the self-examination it models is done before God, not by introspection alone. In Matthew 7:3–5 Jesus

calls us to examine ourselves before correcting another. Romans 14:5 concerns matters of conscience among believers (days and food); the lesson uses it to distinguish a conviction from a custom.

The original word. עֵצָה (ʿēṣâ), "counsel, purpose, plan" (Proverbs 20:5), with דָּלָה (dālâ), "to draw (water)". In the verse the verb is יְדָלֶנָּה, "he will draw it out". The same verb is used of drawing water in Exodus 2:16, 19. The longer explanation, "the intention someone holds and acts on", is a teaching paraphrase, not a dictionary definition.

The book's cautions. Romans 14 is not about marriage, and the lesson does not make every preference a matter of Christian liberty. A family custom is not to be given the authority of Scripture. A real incompatibility is named honestly rather than explained away.

Don't miss this

- Proverbs 20:5 is first about understanding another person; the lesson applies it to knowing yourself.
- Self-examination happens before God, who already knows us (Psalm 139).
- The log comes out before the speck (Matthew 7:3–5).
- Sort each expectation honestly: preference, conviction or deal-breaker.
- Romans 14:5 concerns matters of conscience in the church; its use here is an application.

Talk about it

1. Why do you think disappointment so often shows us an expectation we did not know we had?
2. How can a couple tell the difference between a family custom and a biblical conviction?
3. Why does Jesus say to take the log out of your own eye first?

Remind the group: talk about the teaching, never about anyone's own relationship.

For mentors and pastors. Ask which of their expectations came from home, and which they have tested against Scripture.

Lesson 4 · Learn to Say the Hard Thing

How do I raise something difficult so that it can be heard?

At a glance	
Passage	Ephesians 4:14–16
Also read	Ephesians 4:25 · Proverbs 15:1 · Exodus 18:13–23 · Matthew 5:37
The couple will see	What Ephesians 4:15 means by speaking the truth in love · How to open with a concern rather than a verdict · Three steps for saying what happened: what happened, what I felt, what I needed · How to say it once, clearly, and how to decide what to raise and what to let go
Exercise	The First Real Conversation (prepare alone, then talk together)
Length	About 18 minutes

Purpose. To teach a simple way of raising something difficult so that it can be heard: open with a concern rather than a verdict; say what happened, what I felt and what I needed; and say it once, clearly, with truth and love held together.

Scripture and background. Ephesians 4:14–16 is about the growth and unity of Christ's body: instead of being "tossed to and fro", believers grow up into Christ, "speaking the truth in love". The lesson identifies this church setting before applying it to a couple. Proverbs 15:1 is wisdom about a gentle answer; it is not a promise that the other person will respond well. In Exodus 18 Jethro sees Moses wearing himself out, names the problem, says why it matters and offers a way forward. Matthew 5:37 is about oaths; the lesson draws from it only a secondary point about plain speech.

The original word. ἀληθεύω (alētheuō), "to speak the truth, to be truthful" (Ephesians 4:15). In the verse the form is ἀληθεύοντες, "speaking the truth". The word can describe a truthful way of living, not only truthful speech.

The book's cautions. The three steps are practical guidance, not a biblical formula, and not every irritation needs to be raised. The Jethro story is an illustration of wise counsel, not a passage about marriage. Gentle speech is wisdom; it is never a remedy that makes another person responsible for behaving badly.

Don't miss this

- "Speaking the truth in love": truth without love becomes a weapon; love without truth becomes a hiding place.
- Ephesians 4 is about the church growing up into Christ; its use for couples is an application.
- Jethro sees, names, explains and offers a way forward.
- A soft answer is wisdom, not a guarantee (Proverbs 15:1).
- Begin with a manageable subject, not the hardest one.

Talk about it

1. Why does a verdict leave the other person nothing to do except dispute it?
2. What do you notice in the way Jethro spoke to Moses?
3. Why is hinting so tempting, and what does it cost?

Remind the group: talk about the teaching, never about anyone's own relationship.

For mentors and pastors. Ask how the first practice conversation went, not what it was about.

Lesson 5 · Learn to Hear the Hard Thing

How do I listen when the hard thing is about me?

At a glance	
Passage	James 1:19–20
Also read	James 1:21–22 · Proverbs 12:1; 15:31–32; 18:13 · Exodus 18:24–26
The couple will see	What James 1:19–20 means by "quick to hear, slow to speak" · What defensiveness teaches the person who is speaking · The repeat-back rule: understand first, then respond · How to find the truth inside what you hear, and decide what it requires of you

At a glance	
Exercise	The Other Side (prepare alone, then talk together)
Length	About 18 minutes

Purpose. To teach a person to listen when the hard thing is about them: to understand before answering, to repeat back what they heard, and to let what is true change them.

Scripture and background. James 1:19–22 is first about receiving the word of God: quick to hear it, slow to answer back, and a doer and not a hearer only. The lesson says so before applying "quick to hear" to relationships. The Proverbs teach that hearing before answering is wisdom (18:13), and that accepting correction is the way of understanding (12:1; 15:31–32). In Exodus 18:24 "Moses listened to the voice of his father-in-law and did all that he had said": he heard, and something changed.

The original word. ταχύς (tachys), "quick, swift" (James 1:19). In the verse ταχὺς εἰς τὸ ἀκοῦσαι, "quick to hear".

The book's cautions. Understanding is not the same as agreement. Receiving criticism does not mean accepting every accusation, and listening does not mean surrendering one's judgement. The repeat-back rule is a practical tool, not a command of Scripture.

Don't miss this

- James is first about receiving God's word; the lesson applies the principle to listening to each other.
- Quick to hear means eager to understand, unhurried to answer.
- Understanding is not agreement.
- Moses heard Jethro, and acted. Listening should lead us to consider honestly whether a response or change is needed, without yielding to every claim or demand.
- Correction received is a mark of wisdom in Proverbs.

Talk about it

1. Why does defensiveness make a relationship look calmer while making it less honest?
2. What is the difference between understanding someone and agreeing with them?
3. What changed when Moses listened to Jethro?

Remind the group: talk about the teaching, never about anyone's own relationship.

For mentors and pastors. Ask each person what they learned about the other by listening, not who was right.

PART 3 · WALK THROUGH THE NINE ROOMS

Nine rooms of a marriage, one at a time: money, sex, family, children, faith, roles, the past, what you are marrying into, and conflict itself.

Lesson 6 · Room 1 · Money

What does money mean to each of us — and how will we run it together?

At a glance	
Passage	1 Timothy 6:6–10, 17–19
Also read	1 Timothy 5:8 · Proverbs 21:5; 22:7

At a glance

The couple will see	How to walk through the nine rooms, one at a time · What 1 Timothy 6 teaches about contentment, the love of money and generosity · Why money conversations are often about security, shame, fairness and trust · The facts, the meaning, the rules, and the hard question
Exercise	Room 1 and the Money Snapshot (prepare alone, then talk together)
Length	About 18 minutes

Purpose. To help a couple talk honestly about what money means to each of them, and agree how they will run it together, with contentment, generosity and planning.

Scripture and background. In 1 Timothy 6 Paul contrasts those who treat godliness as a means of gain with "godliness with contentment". It is "the love of money", not money itself, that is "a root of all kinds of evils". To the rich he says: do not set your hope on "the uncertainty of riches, but on God", and be generous. 1 Timothy 5:8 concerns care for relatives, especially widows; the lesson applies the principle of family responsibility. Proverbs 21:5 commends diligent planning; 22:7 observes that "the borrower is the slave of the lender", which the lesson says is not an absolute ban on borrowing.

The original word. αὐτάρκεια (autarkeia), "contentment, sufficiency" (1 Timothy 6:6). In the verse μετὰ αὐταρκείας, "with contentment". In the ancient world the word could describe self-sufficiency; in Paul it rests on God's provision rather than on oneself.

The book's cautions. Budgets, accounts and spending limits are practical recommendations, not biblical commands. Support for parents and wider family is often a matter of duty and culture; the lesson asks couples to name the actual figure rather than settle it in one evening. Financial openness is not the same as financial control.

Don't miss this

- The love of money, not money, is the root of all kinds of evils.
- Contentment is godliness that trusts God's provision.
- Hope in God, not in "the uncertainty of riches", and be generous.
- Name real figures: debts, savings, support for family.
- Proverbs 22:7 is a warning, not an absolute ban on borrowing.

Talk about it

1. Why do you think money conversations so often become conversations about security, shame, fairness or trust?
2. What is the difference between transparency and control?
3. What does Paul mean by contentment, and how is it different from simply spending less?

Remind the group: talk about the teaching, never about anyone's own relationship.

For mentors and pastors. Ask whether they have shared real figures yet, not what the figures are.

If it comes up. If significant debt has not been disclosed, explain why financial honesty matters before marriage. Where it is safe, encourage the person to discuss it with their partner. If they fear the partner's reaction, follow section 3 rather than arranging a joint disclosure.

Lesson 7 · Room 2 · Sex

What are we each carrying into this part of marriage?

At a glance	
Passage	1 Corinthians 7:3–5
Also read	1 Corinthians 7:1 · Genesis 2:25 · Hebrews 13:4 · 1 John 1:9
The couple will see	What 1 Corinthians 7:3–5 teaches about mutual self-giving in marriage · Why different histories are met without shame · What you were each taught, and what you believe now · How to talk about expectations, consent, fears and boundaries
Exercise	Room 2 (prepare alone, then talk together)
Length	About 17 minutes

Purpose. To help an engaged couple talk, slowly and modestly, about the sexual part of marriage: mutual care, honest expectations, and what each person brings into the marriage, without shame.

Scripture and background. In 1 Corinthians 7 Paul answers matters the Corinthians had written about. Verses 3–5 are strikingly reciprocal: Paul describes mutual marital responsibilities of husband and wife, never permission to demand sexual activity. Hebrews 13:4 calls for marriage to be held in honour and the marriage bed kept undefiled. Genesis 2:25 pictures the garden before shame. 1 John 1:9 promises God's forgiveness to those who confess their sins.

The original word. ἐξουσιάζω (exousiazō), "to have authority over" (1 Corinthians 7:4). In the verse οὐκ ἐξουσιάζει, "does not have authority over", said first of the wife and then of the husband. Paul's reciprocal wording is significant, without requiring any absolute claim about every ancient marriage.

The book's cautions. This passage describes mutual self-giving in marriage. It is never an entitlement to another person's body, and consent must be freely given and respected. The lesson distinguishes marriage from engagement throughout. Harm a person has suffered is not sin they have committed. Medical questions belong with a qualified healthcare professional.

Don't miss this

- Paul's words run both ways: the wife and the husband each give.
- Mutual self-giving, never entitlement.
- The course speaks of marriage, not engagement.
- Forgiveness is for sin confessed (1 John 1:9); harm suffered is not sin committed.
- "It will all happen naturally" is not a plan.

Talk about it

1. Why do you think so many Christian couples find this subject hard to talk about before marriage?
2. What is the difference between mutuality and entitlement?

3. Why might “it will all happen naturally” be an unhelpful expectation?

Remind the group: talk about the teaching, never about anyone’s own relationship.

For mentors and pastors. In a group, keep this lesson entirely general. With a couple, ask only whether they were able to have the conversation.

If it comes up. Never ask for intimate details. If a medical or personal question arises, point to a qualified healthcare professional or to a private pastoral conversation.

Lesson 8 · Room 3 · Family and Boundaries

How do we honour our parents and still build a new home?

At a glance	
Passage	Genesis 2:24
Also read	Genesis 2:22–24 · Matthew 19:4–6 · Exodus 20:12 · Ephesians 6:2–3 · 1 Timothy 5:4
The couple will see	What Genesis 2:24 means by “leave” and “hold fast” · Why honouring parents continues for life, and is not the same as obeying every demand · Why family problems are often about arrangements, not feelings · How to agree visits, holidays, privacy, money and who speaks to whom
Exercise	Room 3 (prepare alone, then talk together)
Length	About 16 minutes

Purpose. To help a couple honour both families while building a new home: leaving, holding fast, and agreeing together how much involvement each family will have.

Scripture and background. Genesis 2:24 describes the formation of a new marriage bond: a man leaves his father and mother and holds fast to his wife. Jesus quotes it to teach the significance and permanence of marriage (Matthew 19:4–6). Honouring parents remains (Exodus 20:12; Ephesians 6:2–3), and 1 Timothy 5:4, written about the care of widows, shows that care for family continues. Leaving does not necessarily mean distance; it means a new primary relationship.

The original word. עָזַב (ʿāzaḇ), “to leave”, and דָּבַק (dāḇaq), “to cling, hold fast” (Genesis 2:24). In the verse יַעֲזָב and וְדָבַק. dāḇaq is used elsewhere of people who hold fast to God (Deuteronomy 10:20; 30:20).

The book’s cautions. Honour is not the same as obedience to every demand. Cultures differ widely in how involved extended family should be; the lesson respects that and asks couples to agree the arrangements together rather than settle them by one family’s custom. Marital loyalty never justifies cutting a person off or hiding harm.

Don’t miss this
• Leave and hold fast: a new primary bond, not necessarily distance.
• Jesus uses Genesis 2 to teach the permanence of marriage.
• Honour your parents, all your life; honour is not obedience to every demand.
• Agree arrangements together, not by one family’s custom.
• Care for family remains part of faithful living (1 Timothy 5:4).

Don’t miss this

Talk about it

1. Why do family arrangements so often turn into arguments about loyalty?
2. What is the difference between honouring parents and obeying every parental demand?
3. How can a boundary be an act of love?

Remind the group: talk about the teaching, never about anyone’s own relationship.

For mentors and pastors. Ask how each family is likely to feel about the new home, and how the couple will speak with them together.

If it comes up. Family honour asks for respect and care; pressure to marry, or control of the couple’s decisions, is something else. Help the couple name the difference.

Lesson 9 · Room 4 · Children

What do we each picture when we say “we want children”?

At a glance

Passage	Psalm 127
Also read	Ephesians 6:4 · Deuteronomy 6:6–7 · 1 Samuel 1:1–18
The couple will see	What Psalm 127 says about children and the house the Lord builds · What Hannah and Elkanah show about experiencing the same sorrow differently · How to talk about whether, when and how many, and what parenthood will look like · How to stay on the same side when reality does not match the picture
Exercise	Room 4 (prepare alone, then talk together)
Length	About 16 minutes

Purpose. To help a couple talk about children: whether, when and how many, what parenthood will look like day to day, and how they will treat each other when life does not match the picture.

Scripture and background. Psalm 127 is one of the Songs of Ascents (Psalms 120–134), most probably associated with pilgrimage to Jerusalem. It teaches dependence on God (“Unless the LORD builds the house”) and calls children “a heritage from the LORD”. It is not a promise that every couple will have children. Ephesians 6:4 and Deuteronomy 6:6–7 speak of raising children in the instruction of the Lord, in ordinary life. In 1 Samuel 1 Hannah grieves and prays; Elkanah, who loved her, asks, “Am I not more to you than ten sons?” He loved her, but his question did not resolve her distress.

The book’s cautions. Children are a gift, not an achievement, and childlessness is never a sign of spiritual failure. Christian traditions differ on family planning and contraception; the lesson asks couples to know their church’s teaching and talk with their pastor, and to take medical questions to a qualified professional. Positive discipline is presented as the course’s recommendation, not as a command of Scripture.

Don’t miss this

- Unless the LORD builds the house, the work is in vain.
- Children are a heritage from the LORD, not a measure of anyone’s faith.
- Elkanah loved Hannah, but his question did not resolve her distress. Hannah’s story ends with Samuel, but it is not a promise to every couple who prays.
- Name the years, not a vague intention.
- Grieve together; do not look for whose fault it is.

Talk about it

1. Why can “we both want children” hide a real disagreement?
2. What does Elkanah’s question show about how two people can experience the same sorrow differently?
3. How can a couple stay on the same side when reality does not match the picture?

Remind the group: talk about the teaching, never about anyone’s own relationship.

For mentors and pastors. Ask how each was disciplined as a child and what they would keep. Be gentle with anyone who has known loss.

If it comes up. If the couple disagree about whether to have children at all, do not suggest that marriage will settle it. Encourage them to face it honestly now, with their pastor.

Lesson 10 · Room 5 · Faith and Church

What will our faith actually look like at home?

At a glance

Passage	Colossians 3:16–17
Also read	Matthew 6:6 · Hebrews 10:24–25 · Acts 18:1–3, 24–26 · Romans 16:3–5
The couple will see	What Colossians 3:16–17 says about the word of Christ dwelling among believers · What Priscilla and Aquila show about a shared life of faith · Why “we are both Christians” can hide two different pictures of daily faith · How to talk about church, prayer, Scripture, giving and children, and about different places on the journey
Exercise	Room 5 (prepare alone, then talk together)
Length	About 16 minutes

Purpose. To help a couple talk about what their faith will actually look like at home: prayer, Scripture, worship, church life, service and the faith of any children they have.

Scripture and background. Colossians 3:16–17 is addressed to a congregation: the word of Christ dwelling richly “in you”, teaching and admonishing “one another”, and doing everything in the name of the Lord Jesus. The lesson says so before applying it to a Christian home. Matthew 6:6 commends private prayer; Hebrews 10:24–25 the gathered church. Priscilla and Aquila worked, served and opened their home together (Acts 18; Romans 16:3–5): an encouragement, not a template for every marriage.

The book's cautions. Outward church activity is not the same as Christian character. Some denominational differences can be accommodated; others need serious discussion before marriage. Spiritual leadership is discussed without making one partner the other's spiritual supervisor.

Don't miss this

- Colossians 3 is written to a church; the lesson applies it to a home.
- Private prayer and the gathered church belong together.
- Priscilla and Aquila are an encouragement, not a pattern every couple must copy.
- Name differences of church and doctrine honestly; some are serious.
- Faith at home is mostly ordinary: a table, a road, a bedtime.

Talk about it

1. Why can "we are both Christians" hide two different pictures of daily faith?
2. How do church activity and the faith we practise when nobody is watching belong together?
3. What does it mean to "marry the person in front of you"?

Remind the group: talk about the teaching, never about anyone's own relationship.

For mentors and pastors. Ask what a normal Sunday will look like, and what a normal Tuesday evening will look like.

If it comes up. Where a doctrinal difference is substantial, encourage the couple to talk it through with their pastor or pastors before the wedding, rather than leaving it unspoken.

Lesson 11 · Room 6 · Roles

When we use the same words, do we mean the same marriage?

At a glance

Passage	Ephesians 5:21–33
Also read	Ephesians 5:18–20 · John 13:3–5, 14 · Mark 10:45 · 1 Peter 3:7
The couple will see	Why the same words (headship, submission, partnership) can describe two different marriages · What Ephesians 5:21–33 says, and how sincere Christians read it in two main ways · What both readings share, and four principles that are not negotiable · How to turn your beliefs into an ordinary Tuesday, and into real decisions
Exercise	Room 6: an ordinary Tuesday (prepare alone, then talk together)
Length	About 18 minutes

Purpose. To help a couple discover whether, when they use the same words (headship, submission, partnership), they mean the same marriage; and to turn their beliefs into ordinary days and real decisions.

Scripture and background. Ephesians 5:21–33 belongs to Paul's description of Spirit-filled life (5:18–21), and is taught as a whole: mutual submission (5:21), the wife's submission to her husband, and the husband's love

modelled on Christ, who "gave himself up" for the church. Sincere Christians read the passage in two main ways, complementarian and egalitarian; the lesson describes both fairly. In John 13 Jesus washes his disciples' feet, and in Mark 10:45 he came "not to be served but to serve": authority used in service, which both readings affirm.

The original word. ὑποτασσόμενοι (hypotassomenoi), "submitting" (Ephesians 5:21), from ὑποτάσσω, "to submit, to be subject". In most modern critical editions verse 22 has no verb of its own and takes its meaning from verse 21; some ancient copies include a verb, and the original reading is still discussed by scholars. κεφαλή (kephalē), "head" (5:23): the sense "source" is debated and is reported as an argument, not as the word's definition.

The book's cautions. Treat the passage as a whole, including Christ's sacrificial love, and do not let one disputed word decide the teaching. Four principles are not negotiable on either reading: Scripture is never used to silence a partner; disagreement remains possible; coercion and violence are never acceptable; and marriage teaching never justifies domination.

Don't miss this

- Ephesians 5:21–33 belongs to life in the Spirit and should be read as a whole.
- Husbands are to love as Christ loved the church and gave himself up for her.
- Present both main Christian readings fairly; do not caricature either.
- Same words, two pictures: describe an ordinary Tuesday, not only beliefs.
- Jesus with a towel and a basin: authority is for service.

Talk about it

1. Why do you think the same words, such as headship or partnership, can mean such different things to two people?
2. What does Jesus washing his disciples' feet show about the right use of authority?
3. How can a couple with different convictions about roles still keep honesty safe?

Remind the group: talk about the teaching, never about anyone's own relationship.

For mentors and pastors. Ask each person to describe their ordinary Tuesday five years from now, and listen for where the two pictures differ. Do not press a couple to settle the debate in order to finish the course.

If it comes up. Differing convictions held with respect are not a problem to fix. Using Scripture to silence or control a partner is; if you see that, speak with the person concerned privately.

Lesson 12 · Room 7 · Past Relationships

What from the past needs to be known — and what has grace changed?

At a glance

Passage	Colossians 3:9–11
Also read	Colossians 3:12–14 · 2 Corinthians 5:17 · Psalm 32:1–5 · John 4:1–30
The couple will see	What Colossians 3:9–11 says about truthfulness and the new self · Why not everything you carry is sin · What your partner needs to know to decide freely, and what they do not need · How forgiveness works

At a glance	
	without pretending the past did not happen
Exercise	Room 7 (prepare alone, then talk together)
Length	About 18 minutes

Purpose. To help a couple decide what from the past needs to be known before marriage, and to hold truthfulness and grace together.

Scripture and background. Colossians 3 grounds "Do not lie to one another" in the new life believers have "put on" in Christ; the lesson notes that Paul addresses a church before applying it to a couple. 2 Corinthians 5:17 speaks of the new creation: the past need not be a person's identity, though facts and responsibilities do not disappear. Psalm 32 is David's confession to God, "When I kept silent, my bones wasted away"; it is not a disclosure checklist for a future spouse.

The book's cautions. Honesty is not exhaustive disclosure: a prospective spouse should know what materially affects the decision to marry, but painful history is not for interrogation. Harm suffered is not sin committed. Forgiving someone does not oblige a person to marry them. Past hurt never justifies surveillance or control.

Don't miss this

- "Do not lie to one another": truthfulness belongs to the new life in Christ.
- A new creation: your past does not have to be your identity.
- Psalm 32 is confession to God, not a list for a fiancé.
- Honesty, not exhaustive disclosure.
- Forgiveness does not oblige marriage.

Talk about it

1. Why are "tell absolutely everything" and "don't talk about it" both inadequate?
2. Why is forgiving someone not the same as being obliged to marry them?
3. Why does it matter to say that not everything we carry is sin?
4. What is the difference between honesty and exhaustive disclosure?

Remind the group: talk about the teaching, never about anyone's own relationship.

For mentors and pastors. Ask whether the lesson raised any question on which either person would value independent guidance. Do not ask what was disclosed, whether particular experiences were disclosed, or whether either person has forgiven the other.

If it comes up. If something from the past involves harm or needs more help, recommend individual support for that person rather than a joint conversation.

Lesson 13 · Room 8 · What You're Marrying Into

What already has a claim on our marriage — and have we counted it?

At a glance	
Passage	Luke 14:28–30
Also read	1 Timothy 5:4, 8 · Ruth 2:11–12; 4:13–17 · Psalm 15:4

At a glance	
The couple will see	What it means to count the cost before a commitment (Luke 14:28–30), and why this lesson applies it · The six kinds of obligation a person may bring into marriage · Why a new marriage does not cancel previous obligations · How an obligation can be honoured without governing the marriage
Exercise	Room 8 (prepare alone, then talk together)
Length	About 18 minutes

Purpose. To help a couple count what already has a claim on their marriage: children from a previous relationship, ageing parents, a former spouse, debts, legal and financial commitments.

Scripture and background. Luke 14:28–30 is Jesus' picture of a man who counts the cost before building a tower; it is about the cost of following him. The lesson draws one stated application: wise people count the cost before they build. 1 Timothy 5:4 and 5:8, written about the care of widows, show family care as part of faithful living. Ruth's loyalty to Naomi is honoured by Boaz, and Naomi remains part of the family story (Ruth 4:16); the redeemer customs belong to ancient Israel and are not a template for modern engagement. Psalm 15:4 describes the person "who swears to his own hurt and does not change".

The book's cautions. Legal duties such as custody, child support, court orders and contracts cannot be changed by private agreement and need a qualified professional where the couple lives. Children are never made responsible for adult decisions. Psalm 15:4 never requires keeping a promise that involves wrongdoing.

Don't miss this

- Luke 14 is about the cost of discipleship; its use here is an application.
- Marriage does not cancel existing responsibilities.
- Ruth and Naomi: care for family continues into a new home.
- Keep your word, even when it costs (Psalm 15:4), but never a promise to do wrong.
- Neither "You're the parent now" nor "It's not your child" will work.

Talk about it

1. Why does this lesson say Luke 14:28–30 is applied here, rather than being about marriage?
2. Why are "You're the parent now" and "It's not your child" both unworkable?
3. Why should private preparation remain private, even in this room?
4. How can an obligation be honoured without governing the marriage?

Remind the group: talk about the teaching, never about anyone's own relationship.

For mentors and pastors. Ask whether the couple has discussed the categories of responsibility covered in the lesson, and whether either person needs independent legal, financial or pastoral guidance. Do not ask for the details of their obligations.

If it comes up. Custody, child support, divorce settlements, property and contracts need a qualified legal or financial professional where the couple lives.

Lesson 14 · Room 9 · Conflict Itself

Who are we going to be when conflict comes?

At a glance	
Passage	Ephesians 4:26–27, 31–32
Also read	Psalm 4:4 · Philippians 4:2–3 · James 4:1–3 · Romans 12:18
The couple will see	What Ephesians 4:26–27 and 31–32 say about anger, bitterness and repair · How to look at your conflict as a pattern, not a contest about who started it · What each of you may be trying to protect when you disagree · How to write a Conflict Covenant: who you intend to be when it is hard
Exercise	The Conflict Covenant (prepare alone, then talk together)
Length	About 15 minutes

Purpose. To help a couple decide who they will be when conflict comes: how they will handle anger, repair after a quarrel, and ask for help.

Scripture and background. Ephesians 4:26 quotes Psalm 4:4 in the words of its Greek translation: “Be angry and do not sin; do not let the sun go down on your anger.” Interpreters understand the command in slightly different ways; one common reading is that anger may arise without sin, but must not settle into bitterness. Verses 31–32 call for bitterness, wrath and slander to be put away, and for kindness and forgiveness. In Philippians 4:2–3 Paul asks Euodia and Syntyche “to agree in the Lord” and asks a trusted companion to help; Scripture does not tell us what they disagreed about. James 4:1–3 is used for examining one’s own heart; Romans 12:18 adds, “If possible, so far as it depends on you.”

The original word. ὀργίζεσθε (orgizesthe), “be angry” (Ephesians 4:26), a present imperative of ὀργίζω. The Hebrew of Psalm 4:4, רִגְזוּ (rigzû), can mean to tremble or be agitated (the ESV footnote gives “Be agitated”); it is not identical in meaning to the Greek.

The book’s cautions. Not every disagreement comes from selfishness, and reconciliation is not always within one person’s control. The Conflict Covenant is a voluntary practical agreement, not a binding spiritual covenant; the couple may revise it at any time, and it is never used to compel reconciliation or continued engagement. Ordinary disagreement is distinguished from abuse.

Don’t miss this

- “Be angry and do not sin”: anger may arise, but must not settle.
- Paul does not tell us what Euodia and Syntyche disagreed about; neither should we.
- Look at your own heart first (James 4:1–3).
- “If possible, so far as it depends on you” (Romans 12:18).
- The Conflict Covenant is a voluntary practical agreement, freely made and open to revision.

Talk about it

1. Why might a couple who rarely argues be facing a problem that is harder to see?
2. Why is “What happens between us?” a better question than “Who is the problem?”
3. What is the difference between a Conflict Covenant and a set of rules?

Remind the group: talk about the teaching, never about anyone’s own relationship.

For mentors and pastors. Ask how the couple repairs after a quarrel, and who they will ask for help when they are stuck.

If it comes up. If conflict involves fear, threats or control, stop the communication exercises; this is not a shared communication problem. See section 3.

PART 4 · KEEP TALKING

What to do with what you have found, and how to keep telling the truth for the next thirty years.

Lesson 15 · Keep Talking

What do we do with what we have found — and how do we keep telling the truth for the next thirty years?

At a glance	
Passage	Colossians 3:12–15
Also read	Colossians 3:9–17 · Proverbs 15:22 · Hebrews 3:13
The couple will see	What Colossians 3:12–15 says about the peace of Christ in a shared life · What to do when you find a real disagreement, and the possible ways forward · When to bring someone in, and how to choose them · How a weekly check-in keeps honesty part of ordinary life
Exercise	The Readiness Review (prepare alone, then talk together)
Length	About 16 minutes

Purpose. To help a couple decide what to do with what they have found in the course, and to build the habit of keeping talking for the rest of their married life.

Scripture and background. Colossians 3:12–15 describes the life believers put on together: compassion, kindness, humility, forgiveness and love, with the peace of Christ ruling "in one body". The lesson recognises that Paul addresses the church before applying the principle to a couple. Proverbs 15:22 commends seeking counsel. Hebrews 3:13 calls believers to "exhort one another every day"; the lesson applies it as a regular rhythm of encouragement.

The original word. βραβεύω (brabeuō), "to rule, to decide, to direct" (Colossians 3:15). In the verse βραβευέτω, "let… rule". The picture of an umpire at the games is mentioned only as one recognised way of explaining the word.

The book's cautions. The Readiness Review is a reflection tool, not a score and not a verdict on whether to marry. Postponing a wedding, seeking further counsel, or ending an engagement are all legitimate outcomes, and each can be a faithful decision. Advisers help a couple decide; they do not decide for them.

Don't miss this

- The peace of Christ governs a church's common life; the lesson applies it to a couple.
- The umpire picture is not a method for deciding who wins an argument.
- A delayed wedding can be easier than an unresolved marriage.
- Seek counsel (Proverbs 15:22), but make the decision together.
- Keep talking: a weekly rhythm matters more than any technique.

Talk about it

1. Why might a delayed wedding be easier to manage than an unresolved marriage?
2. What makes a good helper for a couple, and what should a helper never do?
3. Why does a regular rhythm matter more than any technique?

Remind the group: talk about the teaching, never about anyone’s own relationship.

For mentors and pastors. Ask what rhythm of talking the couple will keep after the wedding, and offer to check in with them in six months.

If it comes up. If a couple is considering postponement, help them think it through and pray, but do not make the decision for them.

7. After the course

- **Offer a follow-up.** Many couples value a conversation six months into marriage. Lesson 15 asks each couple to keep a weekly rhythm of talking; ask how it is going.
- **Point to the book.** Each lesson’s **Go deeper** section points to the matching chapter of *Talk Before You Marry*, with its printable exercises.
- **Keep the completion record in its place.** Finishing the lessons never certifies a couple as ready for marriage.
- **Pastoral sessions.** Couples who want help with a particular subject can book a “Talk to a Pastor” session through faithfulpathcommunity.com.

Appendix · Original words in the course

Lesson	Word	Meaning	In the verse
2	οἰκοδομή (oikodomē)	building up, edification	οἰκοδομὴν, Ephesians 4:29
3	עֵצָה (ʿēṣâ)	counsel, purpose, plan	Proverbs 20:5: עֵצָה
3	דָּלָה (dālâ)	to draw (water)	Proverbs 20:5: יִדְלֶנָּה׃
4	ἀληθεύω (alētheuō)	to speak the truth, to be truthful	ἀληθεύοντες, Ephesians 4:15
5	ταχύς (tachys)	quick, swift	ταχὺς εἰς τὸ ἀκοῦσαι, James 1:19
6	αὐτάρκεια (autarkeia)	contentment, sufficiency	μετὰ αὐταρκείας, 1 Timothy 6:6
7	ἐξουσιάζω (exousiazō)	to have authority over	οὐκ ἐξουσιάζει, 1 Corinthians 7:4
8	עָזַב (ʿāzaḇ)	to leave	Genesis 2:24: יַעֲזָב
8	דָּבַק (dāḇaq)	to cling, hold fast	Genesis 2:24: וְדָבַק
11	ὑποτάσσω (hypotassō); κεφαλή (kephalē)	to submit, to be subject; head	ὑποτασσόμενοι, Ephesians 5:21; κεφαλή, 5:23

Lesson	Word	Meaning	In the verse
14	ὀργίζω (orgizō)	to be angry	ὀργίζεσθε, Ephesians 4:26
15	βραβεύω (brabeuō)	to rule, to decide	βραβευέτω, Colossians 3:15

Lessons 1, 9, 10, 12 and 13 have no original-word study; Lessons 9, 10, 12 and 13 teach through a biblical portrait instead.

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